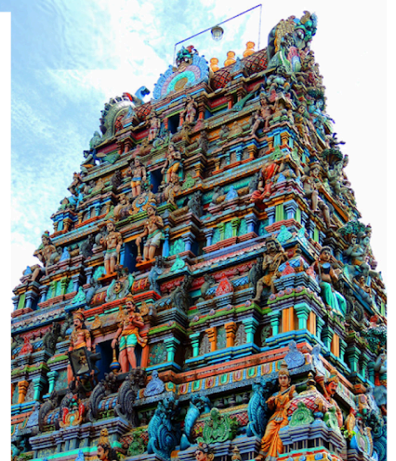


General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Classical Dances of India - II



CLASSICAL DANCES OF INDIA - II

Odissi (Odisha)

- Odissi is one of the oldest and most graceful classical dance forms of India, originating from the state of Odisha.
- Known for its fluid, lyrical movements, and intricate gestures, Odissi reflects the rich cultural heritage of the temples in the region.
- Odissi traces its roots back to ancient temple rituals, performed by **Maharis** (temple dancers) as part of religious offerings to the deities.
- The dance form can be seen in the carvings and sculptures of temples such as the **Jagannath Temple in Puri** and the **Sun Temple in Konark**.
- The dance is performed to Odissi classical music, which is closely linked to **Hindustani classical music**.
- The primary instruments include the **mandala** (a type of drum), flute, veena, sitar, and **manjira** (small cymbals).



(mardala)

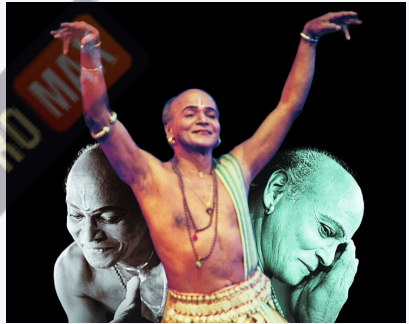


(manjira)

- The caves of **Udayagiri-Khandagiri** provide some of the earliest examples of Odissi dance.

- The dancers create intricate geometrical shapes and patterns with her body. Hence, it is known as ‘**mobile sculpture**’.
- Odissi performances primarily focus on devotional themes, often celebrating the love and devotion between Lord Krishna and Radha or other Hindu deities.
- Many pieces depict episodes from **Jayadeva’s Gita Govinda**, a 12th-century Sanskrit text that is deeply entwined with the performance tradition of Odissi.

Famous Odissi Dancers

Dancers	Pictures
Kelucharan Mohapatra: A legendary figure in Odissi, who played a crucial role in reviving and popularizing the dance form in the 20th century.	
Sanjukta Panigrahi: Known for her powerful performances, she was instrumental in promoting Odissi on national and international stages.	
Sonal Mansingh: A prominent Odissi dancer, also known for her contributions to the preservation of Indian classical dance.	

Sujata Mohapatra: A leading contemporary Odissi dancer, known for her refined and graceful performances	
Other famous Dancers	Kiran Segal, Madhavi Mudgal, Kali Charan Patnaik, Sharon Lowen (USA), Myrta Barvie (Argentina)

Manipuri (Manipur)

- Manipuri originated in the northeastern state of Manipur and is deeply influenced by the religious practices associated with Vaishnavism, particularly the Raslila of Lord Krishna.
- It is deeply rooted in the cultural and religious traditions of the region, particularly connected to Vaishnavism (devotion to Lord Vishnu) and the worship of Lord Krishna.
- Manipuri has ancient roots, with its origins linked to ritualistic dances and the spiritual practices of the Meitei people of Manipur.
- Manipuri is characterized by its soft, fluid movements, which evoke a sense of lightness and devotion.
- It places less emphasis on dramatic footwork or sharp movements, focusing instead on gentle, graceful gestures and circular movements.
- The dance includes subtle abhinaya (expression) and mudras (hand gestures) to depict stories from Hindu mythology.



- Manipuri dance is accompanied by classical Manipuri music, which uses a range of local instruments such as:
 - **Pung (drum),**
 - **Kartal (cymbals),**
 - **Flute,**
 - **Sarangi (string instrument).**



Famous Manipuri Dancers

Dancers	Pictures
Guru Bipin Singh: A legendary Manipuri dancer and choreographer who was instrumental in promoting and spreading the art form.	

Rajkumar Singhajit Singh: A renowned Manipuri dancer, teacher, and choreographer who contributed to the popularization of the dance form.	
Jhaveri Sisters—Nayana, Suverna, Ranjana, and Darshana contributed to preserving and promoting Manipuri dance in India.	
Other famous Dancers	Guru Amli Singh, Nalkumar Singh, Kalawati Devi, Charu Mathur

Types of Manipuri:

- **Rasa Lila:** One of the most popular forms centred on the divine love of Radha-Krishna, where dancers enact episodes from Krishna's life.
- **Pung Cholom:** It is a unique dance that involves dancers playing the pung (a type of drum) while performing acrobatic movements, blending rhythm and dance.
- **Lai Haraoba:** A ceremonial dance that celebrates the creation myths of the Manipuri people and their deities.

Mohiniyattam (Kerala)

- Mohiniyattam is a classical dance form from Kerala, India, known for its soft, graceful movements and emotive expressions.
- The dance is traditionally performed by women and is deeply rooted in the **Lasya** (feminine) aspect of dance.
- Mohiniyattam has its origins in the temples of **Kerala**, where it was performed as part of religious rituals.
- The dance form is associated with the **devadasi** tradition, where temple dancers performed as an offering to the deities.
- Mohiniyattam is performed in **Carnatic music**, and the compositions are often in Manipravalam, a blend of Malayalam and Sanskrit.
- The accompanying instruments include:
 - **Mridangam (a classical drum),**
 - **Veena (a string instrument),**
 - **Edakka (a traditional drum),**
 - **Flute,**
 - **Cymbals.**
- It was revived by the famous Malayali poet **V. N. Menon along with Kalyani Amma.**
- The element of air is symbolised through a Mohiniattam performance.
- **'Atavakul or Atavus'** is a collection of forty basic dance movements



Famous Mohiniattam Dancers

Dancers	Pictures
Guru Kalamandalam Kalyanikutty Amma: Known as the "Mother of Mohiniyattam," she is credited with reviving the dance form in the 20th century.	
Kanak Rele: A prominent Mohiniyattam dancer, choreographer, and scholar who has contributed to the academic study and popularization of the dance.	
Bharati Shivaji: An acclaimed dancer and choreographer who has worked extensively to promote Mohiniyattam on international platforms.	
Sunanda Nair: A renowned Mohiniyattam dancer known for her innovative performances and contributions to the art form.	
Other famous Dancers	Ragini Devi, Shri Devi, Shanta Rao, Tara Nidigadi, Geeta

	Gayak
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Kuchipudi (Andhra Pradesh)

- Kuchipudi is a vibrant and expressive classical dance form that originated in the village of Kuchipudi in the Indian state of Andhra Pradesh.
- Known for its graceful movements, strong narrative storytelling, and unique blend of dance and drama
- Kuchipudi was traditionally a dance-drama form performed by male Brahmins, known as Bhagavathalu, who travelled and performed religious stories, particularly from Hindu scriptures, as a form of devotion.
- The dance form gained prominence under the patronage of the Vijayanagar and Golconda rulers



Unique Features:

- **Plate Dance:** One of the signature features of Kuchipudi is the Tarangam (Plate Dance), where the dancer performs intricate footwork while balancing on the rim of a brass plate, holding a pot of water on their head. This showcases the dancer's control, balance, and agility.
- **Vachika Abhinaya:** Unlike other classical dance forms, Kuchipudi also emphasizes vocal expressions, with dancers occasionally speaking or singing dialogues during the performance to enhance the storytelling aspect.

Tarakas and Angikams: These are two distinct elements of Kuchipudi:

- **Tarakas:** Rhythmic syllables that are chanted and performed to accompany the dance.
- **Angikams:** Physical expressions that convey emotions and actions through movements of different body parts.

- One of the most famous Kuchipudi performances is **Bhamakalapam**, a story about **Satyabhama**, the wife of Lord Krishna.
- The dance is accompanied by **Carnatic music**, and the lyrics are often in Telugu and Sanskrit.

Famous Kuchipudi Dancers

Dancers	Pictures
Siddhendra Yogi: Credited with shaping Kuchipudi into the classical dance form it is today, particularly through his work Bhamakalapam.	
Yamini Krishnamurthy: A renowned classical dancer who played a key role in popularizing Kuchipudi worldwide.	
Raja and Radha Reddy: Celebrated for their duo performances and efforts to popularize Kuchipudi on national and international stages.	

Vempati Chinna Satyam: A legendary Kuchipudi dancer and teacher who redefined the dance form, choreographing numerous traditional and modern performances.



Sattriya (Assam)

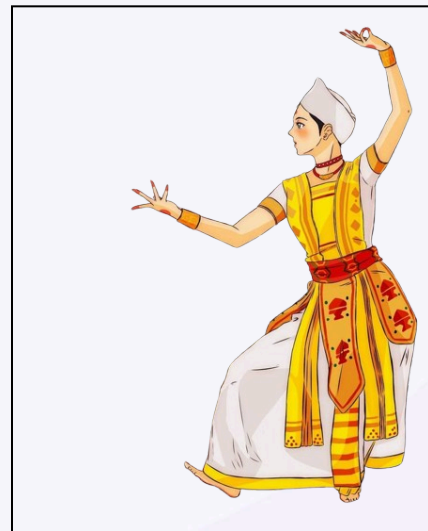
- Sattriya is a classical dance form from the northeastern state of Assam, created by the saint Sankardev as part of the bhakti (devotional) movement in Assam with its roots in Vaishnavism, the worship of **Lord Vishnu**.
- It was introduced in the 15th century by the saint and reformer Srimant
- **Sattriya** was initially created as a ritualistic dance in the Sattras of Assam to spread the teachings of Vaishnavism.

Unique Feature:

- **Ankia Naat:** Sattriya performances often involve a form of dance-drama known as **Ankia Naat**, which includes singing, dancing, and acting. These performances depict episodes from Hindu mythology, often focusing on Lord Krishna and Vishnu.

Types of Sattriya: There are two main styles within Sattriya:

- **Paurashik Bhangi:** The masculine style, characterized by stronger, more powerful movements.
- **Stri Bhangi:** The feminine style, which is softer and more graceful.
- Sattriya performances are accompanied by traditional music which is deeply tied to devotional songs.
- **The primary instruments used include:**



- **Khol (a barrel-shaped drum),**
- **Cymbals,**
- **Flute,**
- **Harmonium,**
- **Violin.**

Famous Sattriya Dancers

- **Guru Raseswar Saikia Barbayan:** A pioneering figure in bringing Sattriya to the national stage, he is credited with reviving and promoting the dance form.
- **Indira P.P. Bora:** A renowned Sattriya dancer and choreographer who has contributed to popularizing Sattriya dance beyond Assam.

Chhau (Eastern India)

- Chhau is a unique and dynamic classical dance form that originated in the **eastern regions of India**, particularly in the states of **West Bengal, Jharkhand, and Odisha**.
- Chhau is a blend of martial arts, **tribal dance**, and storytelling, and is known for its vigorous, energetic movements and use of masks in certain styles.
- Chhau developed in the tribal areas of eastern India
- It was historically performed during festivals, especially during **Chaitra Parva**, which celebrates the Hindu New Year and the worship of **Lord Shiva**.
- **Styles of Chhau:**
 - **There are three main styles of Chhau**, named after the regions they come from:
- **Purulia Chhau (West Bengal):**
 - Known for its use of masks and powerful, dramatic movements.
 - It has a more theatrical style and emphasizes vigorous jumps, leaps, and acrobatics.
- **Mayurbhanj Chhau (Odisha):**



- This style does not use masks, allowing for more focus on facial expressions and emotions.
- It blends smooth, flowing movements with dynamic physicality.
- **Seraikella Chhau (Jharkhand):**
 - Similar to **Purulia Chhau**, it also uses masks, but the movements are more subtle and refined compared to the dramatic nature of Purulia

